

Prologue

Dearest Borān,

lately, I have been thinking about a story I told you when you were a little girl. I remember how much you loved it and you kept asking me about it. As I told you already then, I am not sure where it came from and whether it actually happened. And the longer I reflect on it, the more incomprehensible it becomes. It certainly was the weirdest thing that ever happened to me: so much of it was pure nonsense yet it turned out in one way or the other to be true. If you don't believe me, go ask your grandmother, or mother Gordiyag—they know.

So, befuddled by this thing of my past, I decided to go over it one more time. As you'll notice, I actually retold the story to myself, to see what I can make out of it. But then once I wrote it up, I thought you also might want to read it again, and perhaps tell it to your little boy, Ardashir. Lady Gordiyag wrote to me that he is the cutest boy. Siavash and I might actually come to Tisfon, to visit you, although Shāpur advises us against it. Things are too uncertain there, he says. Perhaps. But I don't want to talk politics with you.

I should perhaps tell you a little more about my youth, so that you can better understand why this dream/episode/adventure/tale—I don't know what to call it—baffles me so much. You might have heard it already before, how your mom and I got to Tisfon, but just in case you forgot.

It all started when Mariam's grandfather, the *Hromāyig* [Roman] emperor Tiberios, died. Her father and uncle were supposed to then share the throne, but her uncle Maurikios seized power for himself. So, the situation became quite precarious for your grandparents and thus, Mariam's grandmother, *Regia* Mataswintha—queen of my people, the Goths—decided that it was safer for little Mariam to be brought to Erān, where she was already betrothed to your daddy Husrow, who, at the time was also still a young boy.

Now, meanwhile, my mommy and I also were living in Konstantinoupolis, in a poor suburb, with the other Gothic fugitives. See, my people used to live in Italia, but when the emperor conquered it, our *Regia*, your great grandmother Mataswintha, and many of her subjects moved to Konstantinoupolis. But then my mommy died when I was ten, and I was sent to a nearby orphanage, where I grew up with my orphan friends—the one that appears in the story, is my friend Alba—she was a Lombard

princess—Albswintha was her real name—, and the story of her life is perhaps even more compelling—but that’s a tale for some other time. Now, when the time came for your mommy Mariam to flee from her uncle, as I already mentioned, *Regia* Mataswintha assigned me as her handmaiden—at the time, I thought it was just because I spoke a little your tongue.

It was one big and scary adventure, getting smuggled into the country, with the help of *Patriarχis* Gregorios and Lord Ioannis—and perhaps, that is another tale I should one day write down—, but we did make it safely into Persian custody. At that time, it was your grandfather Hormozd who was *Shāhān-Shāh*, and everyone treated us with great kindness and hospitality.

Although it was a bit of a challenge—your mommy could be quite a handful, ha, ha—, for me, it had become a big improvement. Instead of sleeping in a cot in the dormitory at the orphanage, I lived in a big palace and even had a little room to myself. For your mommy, it was much harder. She missed her family very much. So, I wanted to tell her a little about her family’s history, our common Gothic heritage. But the point is, at the time, I didn’t really know who I was other than being a Gothic orphan, and therefore a lot of the things in the story, I couldn’t have known. So, how then did I know?? That’s the mystery I cannot solve. As Varaz wants told me

*Fabulae delectabiles
verum fictis miscent.
Sed noli mirari
si etiam mira in veris latent.*

...

*In riveting stories,
we mingle truth with fantasy.
But then, be not surprised
that the fantastical can hide within the true.*

Hope you and little Ardashir enjoy the story.

Your auntie Peristerá.